

The Moment Itself: Chicagovision 2024 - “The Moment”

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What if we just convene, convene
Running through the corn together
Convene, convene
Fireworks that brave the weather
Convene, convene
A polarized assembly
Even if we think differently
We could just convene

– The Representatives, “Convene”, winning song of Chicagovision 2024

Chicagovision 2024, spawn of the Eurovision Song Contest, can truly only be described as an ambiguous convention. Given Chicagovision 2024’s theme, “The Moment”, all five acts seemed to evade a full embrace of the theme given the competition's guidelines. Chicagovision’s apoliticality guidelines made this year's theme an especially difficult one to follow – 2024 is a major election year around the world, the Russo-Ukrainian war continues, and the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, and the global protests it’s garnered, remains one of the biggest pieces of global news at the moment. Altogether, the five acts performed love and heartbreak songs, songs about life in a digital age, and songs attemptnig to satirize the competition or the apoliticality of their moments. Overall, the competition seems very represented by the lyric, “We could just

convene” – convening occurred for the sake of the ChicagoVision competition itself, not the moments each performance represented.

That being said, two acts did share a moment. “Social Media” by Donte and the Doomscrollers and “Free Yourself” by Digitune, both centered themselves around human connection in relation to technology in this increasingly digital age. Again, this “moment”, is an interesting choice given the socio-political state of the world today. I will grant that these acts succeeded in choosing a global moment. Living in this increasingly digital world is a struggle every human is being forced to deal with. Still, choosing this universal “moment” robs these acts of being categorized in our traditional national and nationalist categories.

From a mass appeal point of view, these two groups excel, choosing a moment anyone in the world, regardless of political stance or ideology, can rally around. Tech-optimism today transcends regional boundaries. Interestingly, even with Digitune’s impressive AI-generated music, the performers, supposedly robots, participated in a charming but robotic and rigid dance performance as the AI-generated track played behind them. For those who fear advancement in AI, this serves as a reassurance that human-created art and expression remain unrivaled by technology; for tech buffs, this performance serves as a starting point and exciting glimpse into the future of live performance and creation. Alternatively, Donte and the Doomscrollers performed a cover of “Ophelia” by the Lumineers changing the titular lyric to “social media”. With the lyrics, “social media, you’ve been on my mind girl like a drug”, Donte and The Doomscrollers quite clearly compare social media to a drug. This comparison is a popular, and somewhat undisputed, one, so the choice of social media addiction as “the moment” is a bit puzzling. Warning against reliance on technology, “Social media” could serve as a counter-performance to “Free Yourself”, but given some of the lyrics to “Free Yourself”, like

“threatening humanity”, it seems that these performances oddly align with one another. We will later revisit the complexity of Digitune’s lyrics and performance.

Turning to GULSHENS performance of “Sarışınım”, the GULSHENS take home the award for best emulation of a Eurovision pop performance. This performance felt so familiar that it almost felt out of place in Chicagovision 2024. A cover and band revival of the Turkish singer-songwriter Gülşen’s own “Sarışınım”, the GULSHENS truly celebrate the popular music of Turkey. The tribute to these existing songs marks this performance as national, celebrating Turkish musicians, language, and art through a strong synchronized dance performance by vocalists who evidently sang from the heart. The performers' interaction with the audience awarded their performance a tinge of Eurovision purity - artists sharing their pride for the culture that shaped them and a celebration of the mission of the ESC - to unite people to share song and dance that represents their country. This performance, complimented by the synchronicity of three performers, exuded joy and power derived from togetherness and ... convention.

Ianthe + The Maine’s performance complemented the GULSHENS’ cultural celebration with its Grecian lead singer’s operatic powerhouse performance of a heartbreak song. While Ianthe’s postcard emphasized the national aspect of this performance, with stunning views of Greece and clips of the performers dedicated to perfecting the performance and dance, the act was immediately satirized by the inclusion of an American fraternity brother in the act. This mix, a Grecian and a member of Greek life was no doubt a ploy to gag the audience and was effective in doing so. While Ianthe’s performance without the inserted rapping showed a heartfelt song with solid vocal performance and well-rehearsed movement, The Maine’s Greek rap read off a frisbee quickly turned the performance into satire, watering down “the moment” this performance aimed to portray. All this said, the rap did add a playful attitude to this act and

animated audiences. While the postcard displayed the most national aspect of this act, it's naive of the audience to expect that Ianthe + The Maine wasn't banking off the shock factor after the seemingly non-sequitur inclusion of a same-sex kiss clip at the end of their postcard.

This is just one example of the complicated relationship between this Chicagovision's postcards with the actual performance. Some postcards reflected the messages portrayed in the performance quite well - the Representatives satirized themselves by standing in front of the University of Chicago's Institute of Politics while blocking terms on buildings like "democracy" and "politics", and editing a blond wig on a bald eagle. But, Digitune's postcard flashes a doctored painting of two men where iPhones have been inserted in their hands. This clip comes after a screen claiming that "AI is art", confusing viewers about whether Digitune believes that AI is art or if they find this claim absurd. Suddenly lyrics like "existing needs tech" are taken less seriously while the sentiment behind "free yourself" seems more in line with Donte and the Doomscrollers' moment. While it is still unclear whether or not Digitune's performance serves as a warning or a celebration, the contradictions and lack of observed humanity in this supposedly AI-generated performance solidifies that AI is not art, yet, to the audience.

Finally, as a member of The Representatives, the winners of Chicagovision 2024, I found my journey to Chicagovision peculiar. Our moment, the Democratic National Convention, was deliberately chosen to poke fun at Chicagovision and Eurovision's apolitical guidelines. We performed as prominent members of the American democratic party with stage names doctored to appeal to a more "hip" audience - Lizzy W (Elizabeth Warren) and Hilly C (Hillary Clinton). Lizzy and Hilly evaded their connection to the DNC by claiming that although their jobs were political, their music was not, and that America is a place for convening, regardless of political affiliation. Their vague message of unity was conveyed through their song "Convene", which

celebrated America as a beautiful landscape where one can find themselves if they “just convene”. “Convene” really highlights and satirizes the inability to separate the political from American identity, questioning if it is possible for America, and countries usually participating in Eurovision, to be national without being political. With the American flag being as politically charged as it is, the line, “red white and blue makes light purple” seems absurd. But, it is exactly the fact that we laugh and find this depoliticization of the flag, or the eagle, absurd that argues that this separation is not possible. The juxtaposition of the line “a polarized assembly” beautifully captures the spirit of America on the global scale and the Chicagovision/Eurovision contest at large. With the mission of unification and convening through music, Eurovision, and Chicagovision, are both the most alive spaces when they are polarized. The most memorable performances are almost always making a statement, and the global stage serves as a platform for political messaging regardless of the competition guidelines. It's hard to believe that the Eurovision and Chicagovision do not recognize themselves as political spaces given the allowance of less restricted music video imaging and postcard content. But in case they don't, my message to the ESC and Chicagovision is:

Neither you forgot, nor have I moved on

Don't fool yourself come on oh

– GULSHENS, “Sarışınım”, Turkey's entry in Chicagovision 2024